AVÈRO ADVISORS

TEMPLATE 01

START AT ZERO TOOLKIT · TEMPLATE 01

Phase Zero 100-Day Checklist

Nine milestones from team formation to a defensible Go/No-Go decision, before a single vendor shapes the conversation.

Phase Zero is the work you do before a vendor enters the room. It answers three questions no sales cycle will answer for you: what you actually need, whether your organization can absorb the change, and what it will really cost. Birmingham City Council skipped it and spent £216 million. This checklist turns Phase Zero into nine milestones and one decision over 100 days.

How to use it

- Put a name, not a department, next to every milestone.
- Review progress at every sponsor check-in.
- A milestone is done when its deliverable exists and its owner signs it, not when the meeting happened.
- Scale the windows to your complexity. A county of 400 staff and a state agency of 8,000 will differ.

Core team

Executive Sponsor	
Phase Zero Lead	
Finance Lead	
HR Lead	
IT Lead	
Independent advisor (optional)	

The nine milestones

1. Stand up the team

DAYS 1-7 · OWNER: EXECUTIVE SPONSOR

- ☐ Name the Executive Sponsor in writing, with protected time on the calendar (not a delegate).
- ☐ Appoint a Phase Zero Lead with at least half their time released, and approve backfill.
- ☐ Form a core team of 3 to 5 people covering IT, finance, HR and operations.
- ☐ Decide the delivery model: do it yourselves, or bring in an independent advisor to jumpstart.
- ☐ Confirm that no team member or advisor has a financial tie to any vendor or integrator you may consider.

Deliverable: one-page Phase Zero charter signed by the sponsor. ☐ To do ☐ In progress ☐ Done

2. Kick off and align

DAYS 8-14 · OWNER: PHASE ZERO LEAD

- ☐ Review the business case and the honest answer to "why now?"
- ☐ Agree what success means in numbers (close days, cycle times, error rates, adoption).
- ☐ Set the operating rhythm: weekly core team, biweekly sponsor check-in.
- ☐ Set vendor contact rules: every vendor conversation is logged, and no demos until requirements exist.
- ☐ Assign milestone owners for the rest of this checklist.

Exit test: every core team member can state the objective in one sentence, and it is the same sentence. ☐ To do ☐ In progress ☐ Done

3. Document how work really happens

WEEKS 3-4 · OWNER: CORE TEAM

- ☐ Map 10 to 15 key workflows by observing the work, not by reading procedure manuals.
- ☐ Capture the workarounds: shadow spreadsheets, side databases, manual re-keying, exceptions.
- ☐ Walk the real month-end close and the real payroll cycle end to end.
- ☐ Baseline each process: cycle time, hand-offs, error or rework rate.
- ☐ List the current modifications people would fight to keep, and why.

Deliverable: process inventory with baselines, validated by each process owner. ☐ To do ☐ In progress ☐ Done

4. Map the stakeholders

WEEKS 5-6 · OWNER: PHASE ZERO LEAD

- ☐ Run 20+ interviews across departments, levels and locations.
- ☐ Plot each stakeholder on power and interest (see the Template 05 gate on alignment).
- ☐ Identify the informal influencers: long-tenured staff without titles who shape opinion.
- ☐ Document likely resistance, the reason behind it, and a plan for each high-power skeptic.
- ☐ Agree how and when elected officials or the board will be briefed.

Deliverable: stakeholder power map and engagement plan. ☐ To do ☐ In progress ☐ Done

5. Inventory integrations and test the data

WEEKS 7-8 · OWNER: IT LEAD

- ☐ List every interface, file feed, report extract and system connection, with an owner for each.
- ☐ Assess master data quality: vendors, employees, chart of accounts, assets, customers.
- ☐ Flag duplicates, errors, missing values and records no one owns.
- ☐ Estimate the cleansing effort in staff hours, not just software.
- ☐ Decide what legacy data converts, what is archived, and what is retired under retention rules.

Deliverable: integration inventory and data quality scorecard. ☐ To do ☐ In progress ☐ Done

6. Build the compliance matrix and risk register

WEEKS 9-10 · OWNER: CORE TEAM

- ☐ Document statutes, GASB and grant rules, audit findings, records retention and accessibility needs.
- ☐ Capture union contracts, pay rules and civil service rules that the system must honor.
- ☐ Add security and privacy obligations (PII, CJIS, HIPAA, PCI as they apply).
- ☐ Add AI governance requirements using Template 03.
- ☐ Log every risk with probability, impact, owner and mitigation. Include political, staffing and budget risks.

Deliverable: compliance requirements matrix and risk register. ☐ To do ☐ In progress ☐ Done

7. Assess change readiness

WEEKS 11-12 · OWNER: HR LEAD

- ☐ Survey readiness by department and role.
- ☐ Identify roles that will change, and the skills each will need.
- ☐ Plan training by role, not by module.
- ☐ Nominate Change Champions: about one per 25 to 50 end users.
- ☐ Confirm the backfill plan so subject matter experts can actually show up.

Deliverable: change readiness report and organizational design notes. ☐ To do ☐ In progress ☐ Done

8. Build the business case and benefits plan

WEEKS 13-14 · OWNER: FINANCE LEAD

- ☐ Build the true total cost: licenses, implementation, backfill, data cleansing, training, post go-live support, contingency.
- ☐ Define measurable benefits, each with an owner and a date.
- ☐ Use the Milestone 3 baselines so you can prove improvement later.
- ☐ Confirm the funding path and the approval calendar (council, board, legislature).
- ☐ Outline the procurement strategy and the evaluation approach (Template 04).

Deliverable: business case, total cost of ownership and benefits realization plan. ☐ To do ☐ In progress ☐ Done

9. Make the Go/No-Go decision

DAY 100 · OWNER: EXECUTIVE SPONSOR

- ☐ Compile the Phase Zero Findings Report from Milestones 1 through 8.
- ☐ Score Gate A in Template 05 with evidence attached to every criterion.
- ☐ Decide: Proceed, Proceed with conditions, or Pause and fix.
- ☐ Record the decision, conditions, owners and dates in a signed memo.

Deliverable: signed Go/No-Go decision memo. Pausing here is a success, not a failure. ☐ To do ☐ In progress ☐ Done

Phase Zero deliverables at Day 100

- ☐ Phase Zero charter
- ☐ Process inventory with baselines
- ☐ Stakeholder power map and engagement plan
- ☐ Integration inventory
- ☐ Data quality scorecard and cleansing estimate
- ☐ Compliance requirements matrix
- ☐ Risk register with owners
- ☐ Change readiness report
- ☐ AI Governance & Readiness Assessment (Template 03)
- ☐ Business case, true TCO and benefits plan
- ☐ Prioritized requirements outline, ready for an RFP
- ☐ Findings report and signed Go/No-Go memo

Warning signs you are not really doing Phase Zero

- Vendor demos are on the calendar before your process maps exist.
- Your advisor resells, partners with, or implements any product on your shortlist.
- The sponsor sends a delegate to every check-in.
- No one can quote a baseline metric for the processes you are replacing.
- The go-live date was set by the budget cycle, not by readiness.

Every Phase Zero should end with an honest option to stop. If yours cannot, it is a sales process with a different name.

From *Start at Zero: Leading High-Stakes Modernization in the Age of AI* by Abhijit Verekar. Free to use and adapt inside your agency. © 2026 Avero Advisors. More at startatzero.averoadvisors.com and avavero.substack.com.